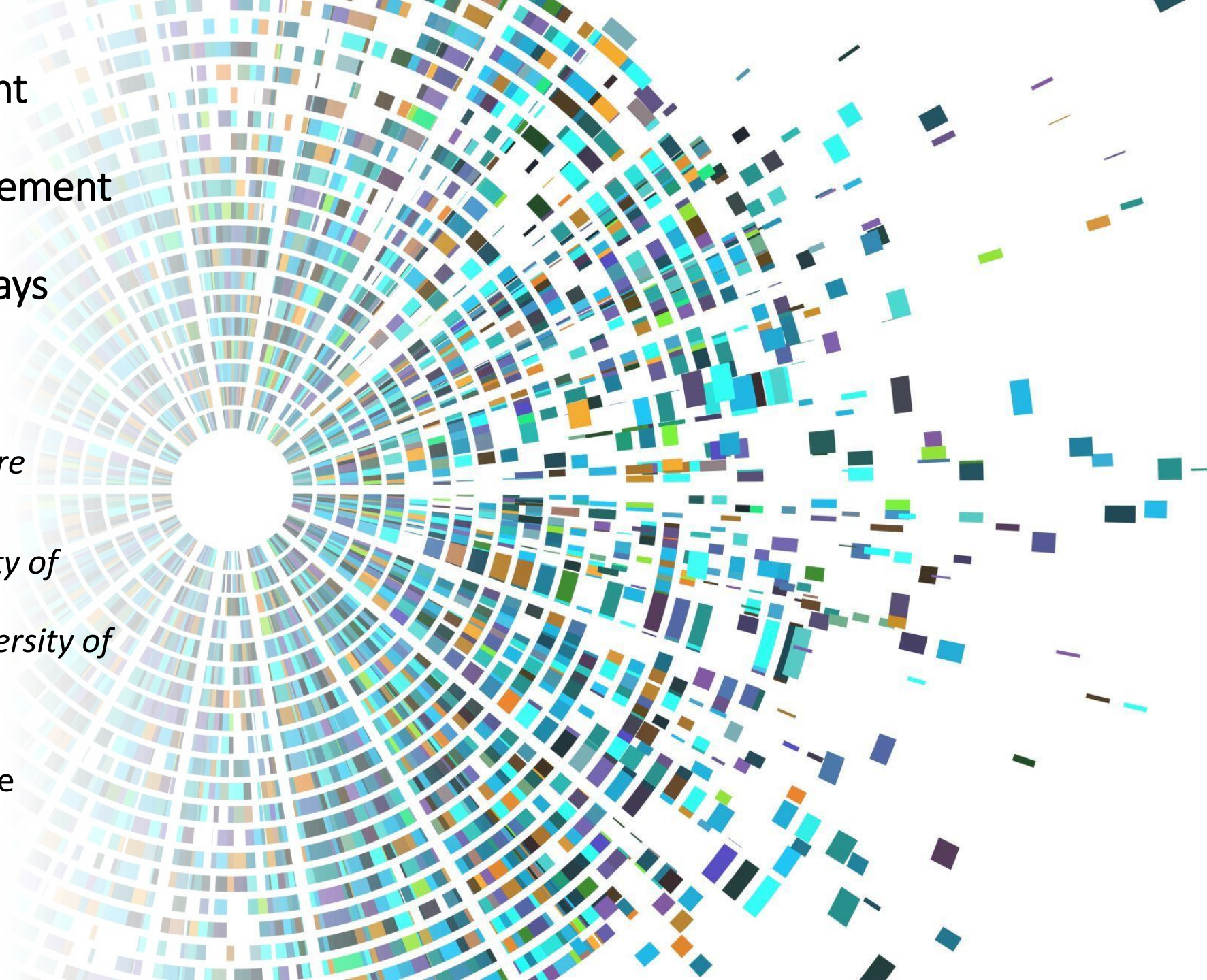


Combining Employment and Community Life Engagement to Support Meaningful Days

- Jennifer Sulewski, PhD, *University of New Hampshire*
- Karen Lee, MS, *SEEC*
- Staci Jones, MS, *University of Massachusetts Boston*
Suzanne Freeze, MA, *University of Massachusetts Boston*
- AAIDD Annual Conference
- June 7, 2023



Introductions



Jennifer Sulewski, PhD, University of New Hampshire

Karen Lee, MS, SEEC, Inc.

Staci Jones, MS, University of Massachusetts Boston

Suzzanne Freeze, MA, University of Massachusetts Boston

Quick poll: Who is here today?

- Person with a disability/self-advocate
- Family
- Service provider
 - employment, day, residential, other?
- Government Agency
- Researcher
- Other?

What is *Community Life Engagement* (CLE)?





How does CLE relate to employment?

- *Leads to employment* through career exploration & networking
- *Wraps around employment* to fill gaps in time, experience, social connection
- *Supports people in retirement* in integrated ways

	<i>Work</i>	<i>Non-Work</i>
<i>Community</i>	Integrated Employment	Community-Based Non-Work/Community Life Engagement
<i>Facility</i>	Facility-Based (Sheltered) Work	Facility-Based Non-Work



ICI Research on Community Life Engagement

2014-2015 Expert Interviews

2015-2016 Provider case studies
Developed guideposts and toolkit

2016-2017 Piloted guideposts and toolkit with 7
providers in 2 states

2019-2022 Developed Guideposts Fidelity Scale and
online modules for service providers

The 4 Guideposts for CLE

~Came from case studies and expert interviews

~Became a set of key principles (guideposts) providers can use to move their CLE efforts forward

Guidepost 1: Individualized supports for each person

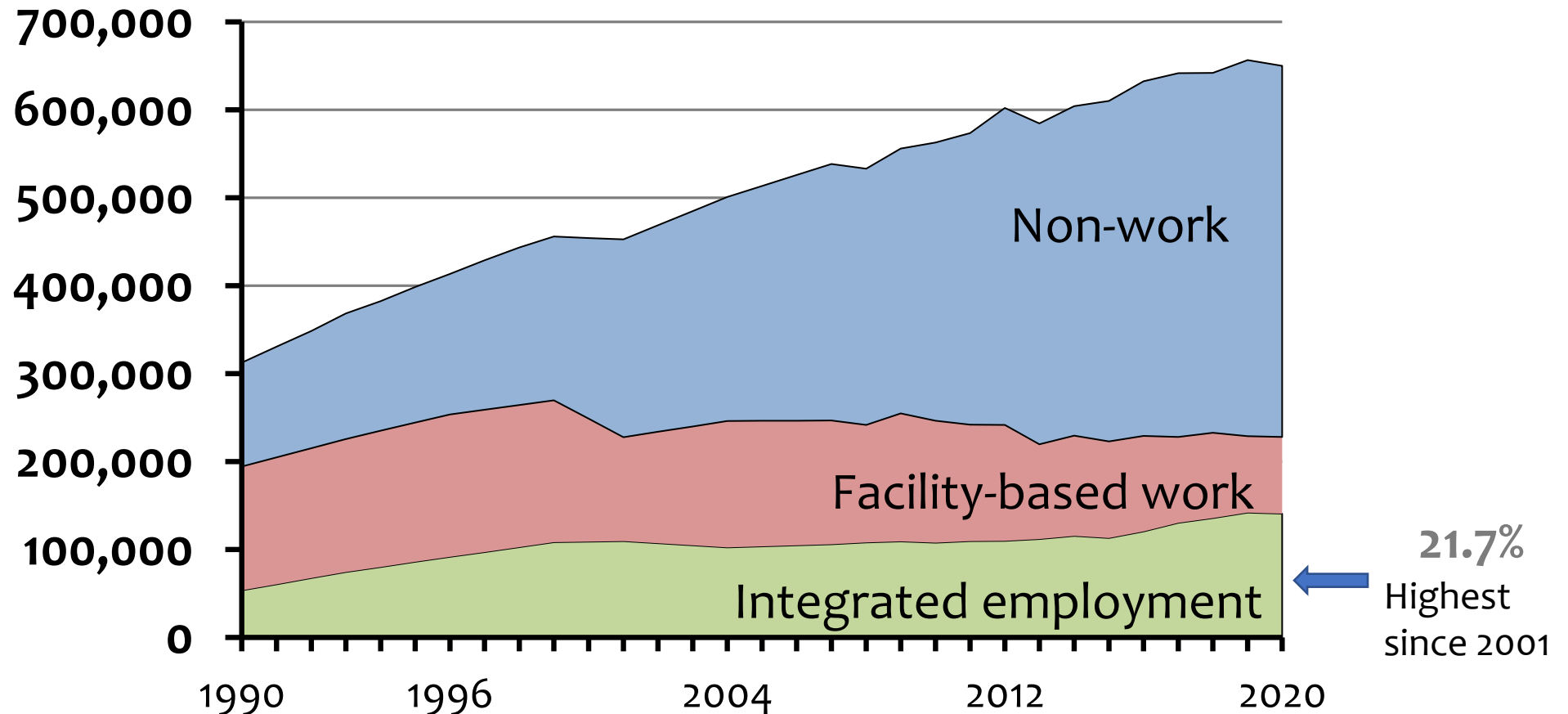
Guidepost 2: Promote community membership and contribution

Guidepost 3: Facilitate relationships and skill building to decrease dependence on paid supports

Guidepost 4: Ensure supports are outcome-oriented and regularly monitored



Number in Employment and Day Services



10 Essential Elements of Provider Transformation

Focus and Values

Clear and consistent goals
Agency culture supports inclusion



Infrastructure

Reallocated, restructured resources
Strong communication plan
Ongoing staff development
Performance measurement & QA
Diverse community partnerships

Employment Consultant & Community Life Engagement Practices

Customer focus & engagement
A holistic approach
Active person-centered job
development



[Agency Change Toolkit](https://act.thinkwork.org/)
<https://act.thinkwork.org/>

Guidepost 1: Individualize supports for each person





Fidelity Scale Questions: Guidepost 1/ Part 2: Person-Centered Supports

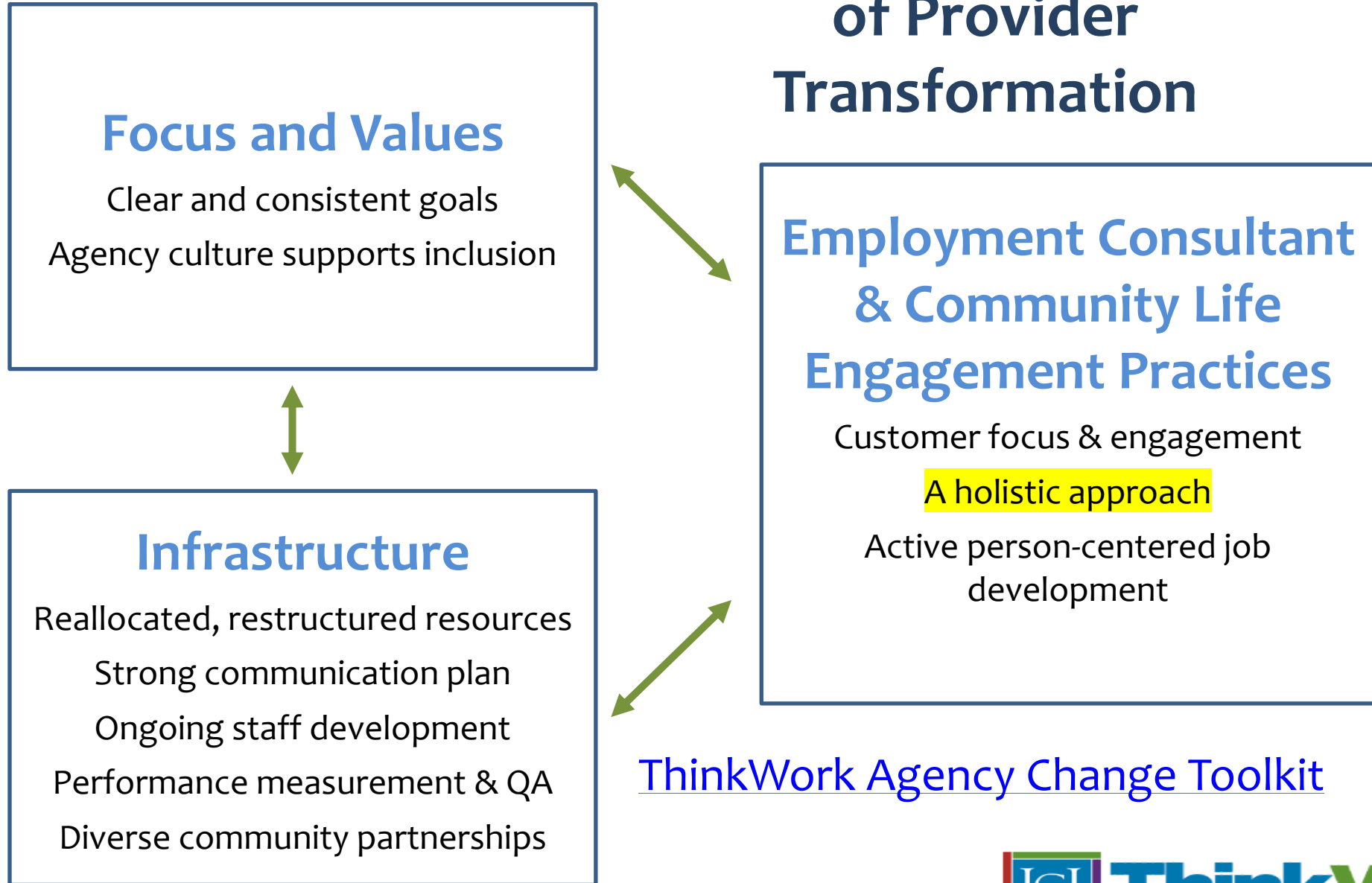
My organization...

- Offers training to staff in person-centered planning or thinking approaches
- Engages the individual throughout the person-centered planning process
- Offers training to individuals on self- advocacy and self- determination skills
- Frequently reviews and updates each individual's person-centered plan
- Supports individuals to develop and plan for life goals
- Is aware of and responsive to individuals' cultural background

Graham and Jessica's Individual Lives



10 Essential Elements of Provider Transformation



[ThinkWork Agency Change Toolkit](#)

Families in Lead and Supporting Roles

Show there is **VALUE** in knowing personal details and doing something about it.

Plain talk:

"what does it mean to work"? There are many pathways you can take.



Guidepost 2: Promote community membership and contribution



Fidelity Scale
Questions:
Guidepost 2/
Part 3: Social and
Community
Connections

My organization...

Trains staff on how to minimize their presence in order to encourage natural interactions.

Supports individuals to form friendships with people outside the IDD system

Gives individuals a say about which peers they spend their time with

Tailors community participation to the individual's desired level of social interaction



Guidepost 2: Promote community membership and contribution





Belonging,
contributing and
membership



10 Essential Elements of Provider Transformation

Focus and Values

Clear and consistent goals
Agency culture supports inclusion



Infrastructure

Reallocated, restructured resources
Strong communication plan
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[ThinkWork Agency Change Toolkit](#)

Families in Lead and Supporting Roles

Start locally with commonly available resources and strategize from there.

Plain talk:

"what does it mean to work"? There are many pathways you can take.



Guidepost 3: Build Skills and Develop Relationships





Fidelity Scale Questions: Guidepost 3/ Part 3: Social and Community Connections

My organization...

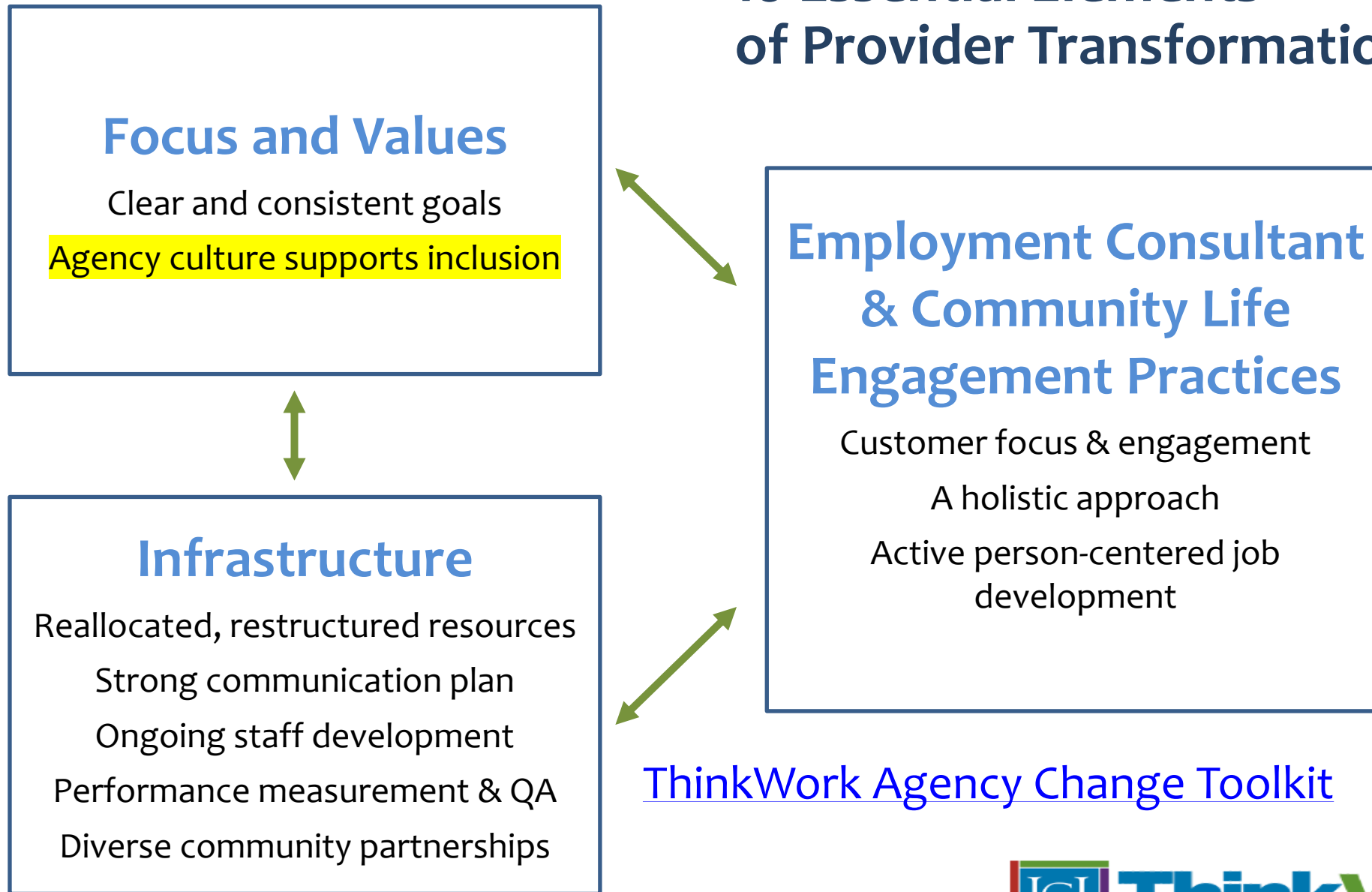
- Provides training to staff on how to identify and build natural supports
- Emphasizes building networks of support from family, friends and community

Charlie at Work and at Play

- Works at Sprinkles Ice Cream Shop 3-5 days a week
- Takes computer class
- Works in a Garden
- Swims with his friends
- Taking a mindfulness class to learn deep breathing for work



10 Essential Elements of Provider Transformation



[ThinkWork Agency Change Toolkit](#)

Families in Lead and Supporting Roles

Explore how to build and improve both **human** and **social** capital.

Plain talk:

"what does it mean to work"? There are many pathways you can take.



Guidepost 4: Ensure supports are outcome-oriented & regularly monitored





Fidelity Scale Questions: Guidepost 4/ Part 1: Organizational Values

My organization...

- Makes sure all working- age individuals have opportunities to explore employment
- Ensures families are aware of the organization's emphasis on individualized, person- centered, community- based supports
- Ensures all staff are aware of the organization's emphasis on individualized, person- centered, community- based supports



Fidelity Scale Questions: Guidepost 4/ Part 4: Continuous Quality Improvement

My organization...

- Regularly reviews data and feedback collected and uses them to improve supports at the individual level
- Regularly reviews data and feedback collected and uses them to improve supports at the organizational level
- Collects feedback from individuals on whether they are supported to achieve the goals they set for themselves

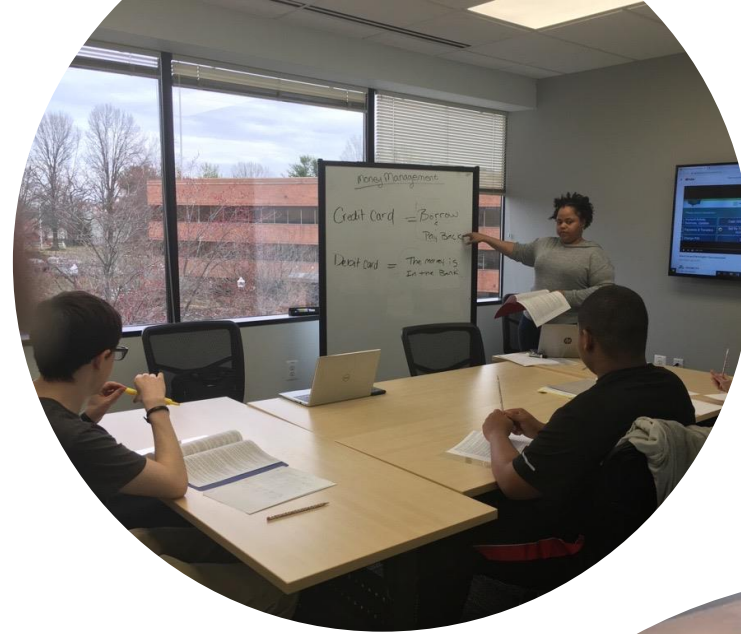
Competitive Integrated Employment is the Outcome



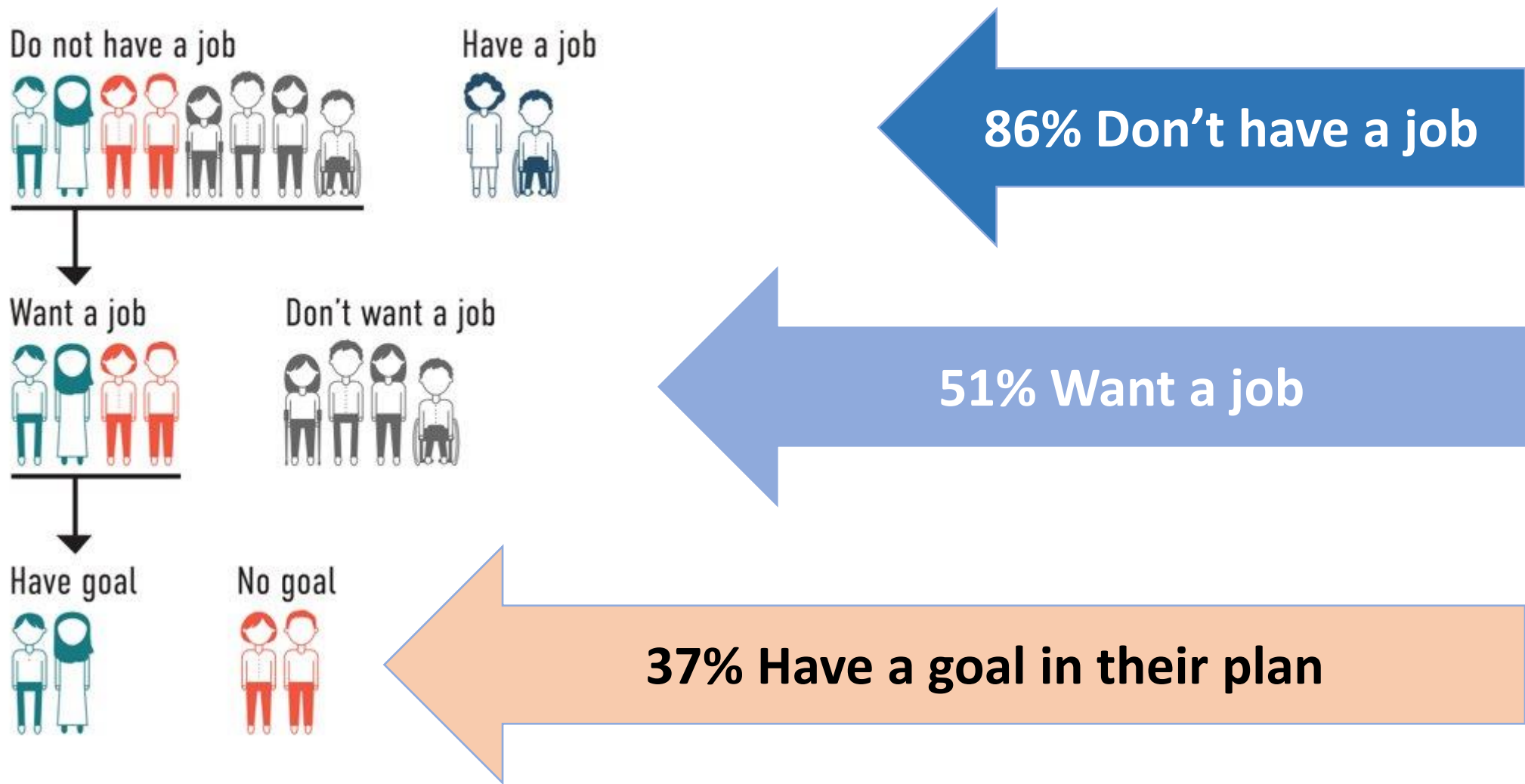
Brett's Journey to Work

CE as a tool to CIE

- Brookside Gardens placing bird feed and cleaning the bird bath
- Taking classes to practice deep breathing to calm down when he gets too excited
- Played basketball with friends
- Worked with a trainer to increase his stamina
- Learned to ride bus and metro



What does the data tell us?



Families in Lead and Supporting Roles

Describe a full life and ask if today is better than yesterday.

Plain talk:

"what does it mean to work"? There are many pathways you can take.



Community Life Engagement (CLE) Toolkit and Resources

Resources:

- About CLE
- About the research
- About the Guideposts
- Promising Practices and Case Studies

CLE TOOLKIT



Welcome to the Community Life Engagement Toolkit

Looking to increase community life engagement of the people you support? Not sure where to begin? This toolkit was developed to help service providers develop and improve high quality supports for community life engagement (CLE). Inside you will find guideposts for success, a self-assessment tool, real-world examples of service providers making CLE happen, and other helpful resources and tools.

Not sure where to begin? Looking for more individualized guidance? Contact Jennifer Sulewski to learn more about technical assistance options from ICI Consulting: Jennifer.sulewski@umb.edu or (617) 287-4356.

The toolkit includes six topical sections:

1. [Background information on Community Life Engagement.](#)
2. [Self-assessment materials to get you started thinking about your own CLE policies and services.](#)
3. [Guidepost 1: Individualize supports for each person.](#)
4. [Guidepost 2: Promote community membership and contribution.](#)
5. [Guidepost 3: Use human and social capital to decrease dependence on paid supports.](#)
6. [Guidepost 4: Provide supports that are outcome-oriented and regularly monitored.](#)

<https://cletoolkit.communityinclusion.org>

Community Life Engagement Fidelity Scale

- Use as a self- assessment tool
- Completed by staff and management
- Answer based on how your day services are currently structured

[guideposts_assessment.pdf \(communityinclusion.org\)](#)

Community Life Engagement Fidelity Scale®

January 2023

This fidelity scale is designed to help providers of day services for individuals with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD) determine their strengths and areas for improvement in supporting individuals' community life engagement. Community life engagement refers to access and participation in the community through inclusive non-work activities such as volunteer work, continuing education, and recreation. For more on CLE and the research behind this scale see: <https://www.thinkwork.org/cle>

This fidelity scale should be completed by staff and management who have a familiarity with the day services and supports offered by the provider.

Please respond to the following statements based upon how your [non-work] day services and supports are currently structured.

For each section, add up the numbers you circled for each response to see where you fall in the range.

Part 1: Organizational Values

Please circle how much you agree the following statements apply to your organization.

My organization...	Strongly Disagree	Disagree	Neither Disagree nor Agree	Agree	Strongly Agree	Enter Number Here
Makes sure all working-age individuals have opportunities to explore employment	1	2	3	4	5	_____
Ensures families are aware of the organization's emphasis on individualized, person-centered, community-based supports	1	2	3	4	5	_____
Ensures all staff are aware of the organization's emphasis on individualized, person-centered, community-based supports	1	2	3	4	5	_____
Total for Part 1	Score Range 3-6 = Low 7-11 = Medium 12-15 = High <i>For more about Organizational Values, visit Community Life Engagement Toolkit, Guidepost 4.</i>					_____



Questions??

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